

Below the Bubble: "Educational Triage" and the Texas Accountability System

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This article uses two dominant traditions in the organizational study of schools—the neoinstitutional and faculty workplace approaches—to explain an urban elementary school's response to the Texas Accountability System. The findings indicate that teachers, guided by an institutional logic, sought to create the appearance of test score improvement by using a constellation of "educational triage" practices. Educational triage was manifest in the diversion of resources to students believed to be on the threshold of passing the Texas Assessment of Knowledge and Skills ("bubble kids") and to "accountable" students (those affecting the school's accountability rating). Teachers also attempted to remove any liabilities to the school's rating by referring these students for special education. To explain why teachers participated in educational triage, the author shows how the equation of good teaching with high test scores by the institutional environment and the district reconstituted both teacher professional identities and teacher-teacher relationships.

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Directing changes in districts' and teachers' practices from above has been an enterprise fraught with difficulties, often leading to minimal reforms (Bailey, 2000; Elmore & McLaughlin, 1988; Fuhrman, Clune, & Elmore, 1991; Fullan, 1991, 1993; McLaughlin, 1991; Sarason, 1990, 1996; Sikes, 1992). Researchers remain plagued by a seemingly intractable dilemma of policy implementation: Educators have consistently failed to implement education reforms. Yet, as both proponents and opponents of high-stakes testing and accountability systems either celebrate or lament, districts' policies and teachers' practices have changed dramatically since the inception of such systems. We must now ask why testing and accountability systems have been successful in altering day-to-day life in school districts and classrooms when so many interventions predating these policies have not.

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While our knowledge of the impact of high-stakes testing and accountability systems has burgeoned in the past decade, researchers have focused their attention on the *effects* of these systems rather than the *mechanisms* that account for districts' and teachers' willingness to change. Such mechanisms are sometimes implied but are rarely fully articulated. Numerous studies point to the motivational qualities of accountability systems, some of which integrate financial rewards and threaten serious sanctions as a factor central to their "success" (Abelman, Elmore, Even, Kenyon, & Marshall, 1999; Achieve, 2002; Finn & Kanstoroom, 2001; Firestone & Pennell, 1993; Fuhrman & Elmore, 2001; Hanushek, 1994; Izumi & Evers, 2002; Kelley, 1999; Kelley & Protsik, 1997). Other researchers contend that districts and teachers experience a moral awakening, displacing their low expectations of poor and minority children and adopting different practices (Koschoreck, 2001; Scheurich, Skrla, & Johnson, 2000; Skrla & Scheurich, 2001, 2004; Skrla, Scheurich, Johnson, & Koschoreck, 2000, 2001).

Alternatively, researchers arguing that negative outcomes result from such systems suggest that a threat from above—that is, from the state, the district, or school administrators—forces educators to change their practices (Figlio & Getzler, 2002; Haney, 2000; Horn & Kincheloe, 2001; Jacob, 2002). While also calling attention to administrative pressure, a more nuanced account adds that teachers shift their practices to ensure that their students can graduate from high school (McNeil, 2000a, 2000b; McNeil & Valenzuela, 2001; Valenzuela, 1999, 2000). Finally, other research offers a technical explanation according to which data made available through regular testing allow schools to more effectively target students' weaknesses (Reyes, Scribner, & Paredes-Scribner, 1999; Scheurich, 1998; Sclafani, 2001). When considered alongside the glaring failure of previous reform efforts to change districts' and teachers' practices, none of these explanations can satisfactorily account for the changes observed. We lack an understanding of what factors have made educators more amenable to altering their practices and how social processes unfold in day-to-day school life in ways that culminate in these alterations.

The present study was based on qualitative data collected in the spring of 2003 at Beck Elementary (BES),¹ an urban school in Texas's Brickland Independent School District. The purpose of the study was to address two interrelated questions. First, how and why have the Brickland district and BES altered their policies and practices in response to the recently instituted "Student Success Initiative" (SSI), which requires third-grade students to pass a reading test to be promoted to the fourth grade?² Second, how and why have teachers chosen to alter or adapt their practices as a result? Early field observations and interviews demonstrated that the response to the SSI could not be understood independent of the broad and deep district- and school-wide responses to the Texas Accountability System as a whole; thus, the study's domain widened accordingly.

I came to understand the constellation of practices used at BES to increase aggregate test scores as a form of "educational triage" (Gillborn & Youdell, 2000). That is, teachers divided students into three groups—safe cases, suitable

cases for treatment, and hopeless cases—and rationed resources to those students most likely to improve the school's scores. Through a series of practices, including focusing on "bubble kids" (those on the threshold of passing the test), targeting resources to the "accountables" (those students included in the school's accountability rating), and decreasing the size of the accountability subset³ by referring students for special education, teachers diverted resources to students most likely to increase aggregate pass rates—the "suitable cases for treatment"—and away from those viewed as hopeless cases. Some of these practices were supported at the district level under the auspices of "data-driven decision making," while others, such as referring students for special education to remove them from the accountability subset, were not.

I was left asking why teachers would systematically and actively privilege some of their students at the expense of others. Given that no rewards or sanctions were attached to the performance of teachers' classes, nor were test scores an integral part of teachers' annual evaluations, I sought to understand what set of conditions made these teachers' responses comprehensible. In exploring the frameworks that scholars have used to make sense of districts' and teachers' responses to external contingencies, I ultimately found that the literature on schools as organizations provided a compelling framework through which to interpret these findings.

In what follows, I provide an overview of the two dominant traditions in the organizational study of schools: neoinstitutional theory and the study of the faculty workplace. While scholars rarely integrate these approaches, I contend that to understand both *how* and *why* the Brickland district and BES teachers have responded to the Texas Accountability System, we must bring together the insights of both traditions. I then describe the study methodology. The subsequent analysis highlights four key themes. First, I argue that the Brickland district's adoption of "data-driven decision making" was guided by an institutional logic. In this section, I demonstrate that data-driven decision making thrives as a rationalized myth because of its capacity to traverse institutionally and technically rational domains. Second, I show how teachers use data to facilitate educational triage in an effort to create the impression, if not the reality, of improvement.

Third, I illustrate how teachers use the loopholes in the accountability system—in particular, the existence of an accountability subset in which all students are not included—to further extend these educational triage practices. Finally, I provide an explanation of why teachers willingly participate in educational triage. I show how the equating of "good teaching" with high test scores by the institutional environment and the district shapes teachers' professional identities. Also, I describe how the district endangers relational trust between teachers by putting them into competition with one another. This atomization of teachers, I contend, accounts for their failure to collectively resist incursions into their practice. I then discuss these findings in the context of the organizational literature on schools. I conclude by considering the implications of this study for our understanding of schools' responses to the No Child Left Behind Act (NCLB).

Theoretical Background: Two Approaches to Schools as Organizations

As described by Bidwell (2001), two distinct approaches make up the study of schools as organizations. The first, neoinstitutional theory, emphasizes the ways in which sociocultural expectations construct the work of schools. The second, which I refer to here as the "faculty workplace tradition," attends to the implications of the social organization of teachers for what happens in classrooms and schools. I review these approaches in turn, with the underlying goal of leveraging the insights of both literatures to understand better the processes through which schools are responding to accountability systems.

Neoinstitutional Theory

Rejecting the notion that changes in organizational structures arise in response to environmental pressures for technical efficiency, early institutional work drew attention to schools' adoption of "rationalized myths." These myths are salient understandings about how work should be structured to achieve organizational goals (Meyer & Rowan, 1977, 1978). Accordingly, schools become isomorphic with the institutional environment in order to achieve legitimacy and ensure their survival. DiMaggio and Powell (1983) built upon this approach, describing three types of isomorphism: mimetic, coercive, and normative. They posited that, in periods of uncertainty, organizations model themselves after similar organizations perceived to be either more successful or more legitimate; they referred to this process as mimetic isomorphism. They described coercive isomorphism as a process by which state agencies and cultural expectations exert formal and informal pressures on organizations. Finally, DiMaggio and Powell highlighted two mechanisms of normative isomorphism: first, the legitimating power of formal education and university specialists and, second, the growth of professional networks that span boundaries and through which new models diffuse.

Since the publication of early institutional work on education (Meyer & Rowan, 1977, 1978; Weick, 1976), a series of exogenous shocks have fundamentally altered the institutional environment in which districts and schools are ensconced. Following *A Nation at Risk's* call to arms (National Commission on Excellence in Education, 1983), state and federal education policy has moved from privileging compliance to emphasizing student performance on standardized tests (Adams & Kirst, 1999; Elmore, Abelman, & Fuhrman, 1996; Fuhrman, 1999; Heubert & Hauser, 1999; Linn, 2000; Olsen, Jones, & Bond, 2001). State accountability systems, such as that implemented in Texas in 1993, have created a singular public vocabulary for discussing school reform.⁴ For example, the Texas Education Agency (TEA) labels schools as "exemplary," "recognized," "acceptable," or "low performing" on the basis of students' scores, and these ratings are publicly reported.

At the same time that the institutional environment of education was evolving, neoinstitutional theorists began to add nuance to their founding statements.

Thus, while originally conceptualized as an alternative to notions of organizations as rational, goal-driven entities, neoinstitutional theory now recognizes that institutional forces and technical efficiency are not diametrically opposed (Perrow, 1986; Powell, 1991; Rowan & Miskel, 1999; Scott & Meyer, 1991). For example, an organization might respond to institutional pressures by adopting a prevalent practice in order to achieve legitimacy. This practice, however, might also increase technical efficiency. While early neoinstitutional work held that organizations insulated their technical core by making symbolic structural changes and decoupling these structures from classroom practice, recent studies indicate that the institutional environment does in fact infiltrate the technical core (Coburn, 2004; Rowan & Miskel, 1999).

The Faculty Workplace Tradition

In contrast to neoinstitutional theorists, authors writing in the faculty workplace tradition hold that the factors that determine the functioning of schools come from within. These studies highlight the ways in which teachers' beliefs and practices are subject to collegial social control (Bidwell & Yasumoto, 1999; Yasumoto, Kazuaki, & Bidwell, 2001), subject matter comes to shape teachers' professional identities and professional communities (Siskin, 1994; Stodolsky, 1988), and relationships with other teachers condition teachers' work and the communities of practice that ensue (Bryk & Driscoll, 1988; Bryk, Lee, & Holland, 1993; Bryk & Schneider, 2002; Cochran-Smith & Lytle, 1999; McLaughlin & Talbert, 2001; Talbert & McLaughlin, 1994).

Most relevant to this study is Bryk and Schneider's (2002) work on relational trust, which maintains that the quality of social relationships within schools strongly influences how well they function, particularly in periods of reform and change. In a school context, teachers, principals, parents, and students remain incredibly interdependent, which breeds feelings of vulnerability across parties. Bryk and Schneider held that role relationships undergird the within-school social exchanges that occur between, for example, teachers and other teachers, teachers and parents, and teachers and their principal.⁵ Each party in these relationships maintains an understanding of both his or her role obligations and the role obligations of the other parties. If role obligations are not met, individuals will withdraw their trust. Bryk and Schneider identified respect, competence, personal regard for others, and integrity as the four key elements of relational trust. In summary, Bryk and Schneider (2002) conceived of relational trust as an "organizational property in that its constitutive elements are socially defined in the reciprocal exchanges among participants in a school community" (p. 22).

The majority of studies of schools as organizations adopt either an institutional or a faculty workplace approach, failing to examine how the institutional environment may affect the capacity of faculty members to form and sustain collegial relationships. Bidwell's (2001) reconciliation of neoinstitutional and faculty workplace frameworks begins to address this divide. Bidwell located the stability of the formal organizational structures of schools in

the desire of central office administrators to achieve legitimacy by maintaining the conventional organization of teachers' work and in the ability of informal faculty networks to collectively solve problems, acclimate to local contingencies, and resist pressures to change practices. Faculty networks, then, shield the formal organization of instruction from change. Bidwell predicted that initiatives designed to improve quality of instruction are unlikely to be implemented because of the tendency for "local cultures of practice to resist change in the absence of strong shocks to their institutionalization and their centrality to teachers' individual occupational identities" (p. 112).

The implementation of high-stakes testing and accountability systems has provided the type of shock to the institutional environment to which Bidwell referred, potentially altering the relationship between local cultures of practice and teachers' professional identities. This study thus afforded a unique opportunity to examine the dynamic interplay of institutional and faculty workplace forces as factors in districts' and teachers' responses to the Texas Accountability System and, in doing so, to bring these branches of organizational theory into conversation with one another.

Method

Design and Participants

According to Yin (1994), the case study research strategy is fitting in circumstances in which "the boundaries between phenomenon and context are not clearly evident" (p. 13). Because the history, culture, and unique circumstances of a school mediate its response to external contingencies such as those associated with the Texas Accountability System, I used a case study design, enabling the school and district context to be taken into account.

Since many dispute the impact of the Texas Accountability System on poor and minority children who have historically attended neglected schools, I selected a school with an economically disadvantaged, minority population.⁶ Moreover, the limited research on elementary schools' responses to the Texas Accountability System has focused on exemplary schools (Council of Chief State School Officers, 2002; Reyes et al., 1999; Scheurich, 1998), leaving a gap in our understanding of how the average Texas school is reacting to these demands.

On the basis of these criteria, I ultimately chose to study BES, a prekindergarten through fifth-grade school located in an impoverished urban neighborhood in the Brickland Independent School District. In 2003, more than 90% of BES students qualified for free or reduced-price lunches; almost all of the school's students are Hispanic (TEA, 2003a). (Approximate percentages are provided to protect the confidentiality of the school and the district.) The Hispanic students include first-, second-, and third-generation immigrants as well as students whose families have resided in Texas for longer periods of time. Since the inception of the Texas Accountability System in 1993, BES has received an "acceptable" rating from the TEA; it has yet to reach "recognized" status (defined, at the time of this study, as more than 80% of stu-

dents passing), much to the frustration of the teachers and the administration. In general, there is a considerable desire among the staff and administration to achieve the "recognized" rating.⁷

I collected data through participant observation techniques and document review, in addition to conducting 34 interviews with teachers and school and district administrators; the goal was to triangulate each mode of data collection. Using a semistructured format, I interviewed 26 of the school's 28 teachers for a modal length of 45 minutes.⁸ Informal interactions on the playground, during lunch, and at social events, in which the teachers graciously included me, served to supplement the formal interview data. I also interviewed the five individuals in administrative positions: the principal, vice-principal, counselor, instructional facilitator, and literacy coordinator. These interviews generally lasted 60 to 90 minutes. Three 90-minute interviews were also conducted with key district administrators who were primarily responsible for elementary education in the Brickland district. Interviews were tape recorded and transcribed.

I acted as a participant-observer for a total of 180 hours. Participant observation settings included third- and fourth-grade classrooms, third-grade tutoring sessions with the literacy teacher, meetings of teachers and parents, and special events (e.g., pep rallies). Documents included teachers' lesson plans, all e-mails and memos sent to staff throughout the school year, minutes of faculty meetings, grade-level "strategic planning" documents,⁹ and narrative information from students' intervention folders, which provide multi-year running records of individual students. Finally, I collected quantitative test score data and family background information on each of the 86 third-grade students with the goal of verifying long-term student achievement patterns as well as the claims that teachers made about their students. Such data included benchmark test scores, Texas Assessment of Knowledge and Skills (TAKS) scores, test scores in Grades K-2, report cards, attendance, language spoken at home, and residential mobility. Because the focus here is on mechanisms rather than effects, these quantitative data serve only a descriptive function in this article.

Data Analysis

In the first analyses of these data, interview data, along with documentary evidence and field notes, were coded openly through the use of thematic categories generated from the language of the informants: "data driven," "bubble kids," "good/bad teachers," "accountables," "special education," and "DNQs" (i.e., those who did not qualify for special education) (Emerson, Fretz, & Shaw, 1995). Within each of these categories, a series of subcodes was generated inductively; a total of 98 codes were used. Initially, I analyzed teachers as individual cases. For each pattern that emerged from this coding process—for example, that teachers focused their attention on "bubble kids"—I created a within-case display (Miles & Huberman, 1994) that presented the information on this claim gathered from each mode of data collection. Both within and across these modes of data collection, I sought disconfirming evidence. On the

basis of this analysis, I developed a case summary for each teacher that enumerated his or her use of each of these educational triage practices and detailed the personal contexts in which he or she adopted these practices. I then created a cross-case display that treated each of the teachers as individual cases, providing a means to compare the practices on each of these domains. The same procedure was repeated for administrators. Teachers' and administrators' data were then merged into one display, allowing for subtle differences in their viewpoints to emerge.

In response to reviewers' comments, my attention was drawn to the theoretical work on schools as organizations. A second analysis, grounded in the neoinstitutional and faculty workplace literatures, was then conducted. I used theoretically driven codes in an attempt to better understand the mechanisms accounting for the adoption of these educational triage practices. I conducted the same series of procedures just described for the initial analysis. The findings described here draw on both of these analyses. The quotations presented are limited to those that represent the general sentiments observed in the field (Erickson, 1985).

Results

Adoption of Rationalized Myths: Data-Driven Decision Making

Unlike the ambiguous institutional environment in education discussed in early neoinstitutional theory, today's institutional environment privileges the production of a singular output: test scores. The means by which these results are achieved, however, have also become the object of public discourse in Texas. In accordance with Meyer and Rowan's (1977) assertion that organizations adopt rationalized myths to achieve legitimacy, the means for achieving results have become highly institutionalized in Texas, or "infused with value beyond the technical requirements of the task at hand" (Selznick, 1957, p. 17).

Beginning in the mid-1990s, the media regularly lauded a handful of Texas districts for improving their test scores using a system of data-driven decision making.¹⁰ This trend was further encouraged by the TEA's iteration of its belief that successful schools are "data driven," as evidenced by their public exaltation of the "responsible" educator as one who makes decisions on the basis of data.¹¹ In short, in the period of institutional change precipitated by the implementation of the Texas Accountability System, data-driven decision making has become a new marker of legitimacy.

The accounts provided by Brickland district administrators to explain the district's adoption of data-driven decision making can be understood through the lens of DiMaggio and Powell's (1983) concept of "mimetic isomorphism." As Marguerite, the principal of BES, related:

Everything needs to be data driven. In '92 and '93, it was just about good instruction, that the teachers had to be delivering good instruction. In

"Educational Triage" and the Texas Accountability System

'95 and '96, I started to see [data-driven decision making] more. . . . Really, that was the buzzword here in Texas.

While Brickland's initial determination to adopt data-driven decision making can be understood as mimetic, coercive and normative isomorphic forces later served to buttress and sustain this choice. As discussed earlier, the TEA has made clear its preference for data-driven decision making as a means for achieving results. While the TEA does not hold districts and schools accountable for the process through which results are achieved, Brickland district administrators believed that operating under the auspices of data-driven decision making and maintaining extensive documentation of student achievement would protect the district from challenges by the TEA. The TEA's preferences, then, amounted to a form of coercive isomorphic pressure. Normative isomorphic pressures also served to solidify the system of data-driven decision making, and university specialists and professional organizations have played a major role in legitimating the system. Recent educational literature is replete with exhortations that teachers and schools should use data in making their decisions (Armstrong & Anthes, 2001; Just for the Kids, 2000; National School Board Foundation, 2003; Streifer, 2002).

Consequently, a single phrase—"becoming data driven"—encapsulates the vision of education reform in the Brickland school district.¹² Brickland administrators, as well as the principal and other members of the BES team, provided similar public accounts of what it means to be data driven. As Naomi, a Brickland district administrator, explained:

Data driven means to me . . . going back and testing. It's . . . finding out what's wrong, remediating it, testing it again, and did they get it? If they did, then you can go on to something else, and if they didn't, then what am I going to do differently? That's what I mean by using your data. It's kind of like, oh, they didn't pass the test. Oh, we need to work harder. But if you don't use your data, you don't know where.

Yet, Brickland administrators did not describe data-driven decision making as simply a means to an end; rather, they valorized this system as the "right" way for districts, schools, and teachers to operate. The result is that data-driven decision making has become a valued end in itself. Other reforms put into place in the past 10 years—for example, class-size reductions in Grades K–3 and school-based governance reforms—were never mentioned as a source of school improvement. Instead, data-driven decision making was seen as the key reform strategy, and gains in test score performance were understood almost exclusively as a result of this practice. In summary, Brickland district administrators celebrate the adoption of data-driven practices as *the* variable differentiating "successful" and "unsuccessful" schools in the district. The same regard for data-driven practices exists at the level of school administration; significantly, the principal of BES believes that becoming data driven has been the most important factor in improving the school's test scores.

By what kind of data, then, are Brickland schools and teachers driven, and how are teachers supposed to use these data? Although the TEA encourages schools to evaluate "a wide range of data," Brickland administrators recognize that, in the Texas Accountability System, only one kind of data—TAKS scores—ensures officially sanctioned success. Consequently, it is not surprising that district- and school-level discussions of data, and of success, are limited to scores on the three practice TAKS tests administered throughout the year in all district schools and the official TAKS tests. The district not only administers these practice tests, but also delineates the data-driven processes that teachers should use following the tests. After each test, students are scored in two ways: via an aggregate score and via a score for each objective.¹³ If a student scores above 70%, teachers and administrators refer to her or him as a "passer." If a student scores between 60% and 69%, the student is labeled a "bubble kid" because her or his score leaves her or him on the "bubble" below the passing score established by the district. Finally, if a student scores below 60%, she or he is labeled a "foundation kid" or a "remedial kid." These categories, created by the district, provide the vocabulary through which students are discussed.

After each test, all of the teachers in a grade level meet, share their respective passing rates, and calculate the percentage of students at the grade level passing each objective and passing overall.¹⁴ The district then requires teachers to set a target number of students who will pass the next benchmark test. This target is calculated by assuming that the "bubble kids" will become "passers." Thus, the impetus is to ensure that bubble kids pass the next benchmark test. While the district does not administer uniform benchmark tests for students in Grades K–2, state-sponsored reading inventories and other teacher-made tests are used in the same way at BES, with targets also set for the following test.

In summary, in response to institutional pressures, the Brickland district has implemented an intricate monitoring system that emphasizes a singular measure of student achievement. Sidestepping the key problems in making judgments about teachers' competence—the multiple ends of schooling and the privacy of elementary classrooms (Bryk & Schneider, 2002)—Brickland has focused attention on one outcome and made the performance of individual teachers visible. According to Bryk and Schneider, teachers' sense of vulnerability is amplified by the focus on the failures and inadequacies of schools during times of reform. Individualizing the performance of teachers under this system of data-driven decision making led to increases in such feelings of vulnerability. Interestingly, the system has no formal rewards or sanctions attached to it; neither principals' nor teachers' contracts are tied to students' ultimate performance on these tests. Nevertheless, as I describe in the following section, teachers at BES actively participated in the form of "educational triage" designed by the district to increase aggregate test scores by diverting additional resources to students believed to be on the threshold of passing the test, that is, the bubble kids. At BES, invocation of the phrase "data driven" obscures, neutralizes, and legitimates this system of resource

distribution designed to increase aggregate test scores rather than to meet the needs of individual students.

Using Data to Facilitate "Educational Triage"

At BES, teachers do not simply describe bubble kids as "those scoring between 60% and 69%." Instead, teachers articulate and enact a plan of action that can best be understood through British researchers Gillborn and Youdell's (2000) concept of "educational triage." Gillborn and Youdell hold that, in the service of increasing a school's aggregate test scores on the English national secondary school assessment, students are divided into three groups: non-urgent cases, suitable cases for treatment, and hopeless cases. Schools then effectively ration their resources by directing them toward students believed to benefit the school's aggregate performance most: the suitable cases for treatment. Gillborn and Youdell's application of the idea of triage, a practice usually operating in dire circumstances such as the battlefield or the emergency room, to education perceptively captures the dynamics of BES's experience under the Texas Accountability System. At BES, some students must be sacrificed in the name of improving the school's aggregate scores, and the stakes are high for both students, who can be retained in the third grade for failing the state's reading test, and teachers, who are judged (by themselves and their peers) according to the number of students they "save." The following were typical responses to a question I added to my interview protocol: "Who are the bubble kids?"

The ones that will pass with a little more help. With the pink ones [the remedial kids], it's really a lost cause. They must have fallen through the cracks somehow. (Luis)¹⁵

Those are the ones that you can count on to pass if you move them up a little bit. They're the ones we do one-to-one with and small group instruction in class. (Christina)

The ones who miss by one or two points—they just needed a little extra help to pass so we concentrate our attention on that group. The bubbles are the ones who could make it. (Benita)

They are your first priority, the ones whose folders you move to the top of your pile. (Milagros)

Alluded to in these quotations are some of the interventions mobilized to bump bubble kids into the passing range:

- Time in class is focused on giving bubble kids extra help, either one on one or in small groups.
- The literacy teacher has sessions with the bubble kids throughout the school day.
- After-school and Saturday tutoring target the bubble kids.
- Summer school programs for K–2 students serve the bubble kids.

- Music, gym, and library teachers, in lieu of teaching their assigned subjects, engage in test preparation activities with small groups of bubble kids.

In short, the overwhelming majority of the interventions that the school has to offer focus on the bubble kids. These interventions span almost the entire school year, beginning in August and continuing through the end of April when the TAKS test is administered.

Invoking phrases such as “the ones who could make it” and “hopeless cases” speaks not only to the perceived urgency to increase aggregate test scores but also to the labels forced onto those children who find themselves below the bubble. As Noreen, one of the teachers, explained:

I guess there's supposed to be remediation for anything below 55, but you have to figure out who to focus on in class, and I definitely focus more attention on the bubble kids. If you look at her score [pointing to a student's score on her class summary sheet], she's got a 25%. What's the point in trying to get her to grade level? It would take 2 years to get her to pass the test, so there's really no hope for her. . . . I feel like we might as well focus on the ones that there's hope for.

With an unforgiving bottom line for which to strive, this teacher feels that she can retain “hope” only for those perceived as potential passers. To assert—as does Donald, the teacher quoted in the following excerpt—that these students below the bubble are “just too low” establishes that the only worthwhile improvement is one that converts a bubble kid to a passer.

If you have a kid who is getting a 22, even if they improve to a 40, they won't be close—but if you have a kid with a 60, well, they're in shooting range. Bush says that no child should be left behind, but . . . the reality in American public schools is that some kids are always going to be left behind, especially in this district, when we have the emphasis on the bubble kids. Some are . . . they're just too low.

Paradoxically, a large improvement, essentially doubling a student's score (22% to 40%), is seen as inconsequential relative to a moderate gain that propels a student above the district's established 70% mark.

Because the focus on bubble kids begins not in the third grade, the first year that students take the TAKS, but at the moment students enter kindergarten, students experience this triage system throughout their entire elementary school careers. Even the state-mandated interventions for the lower grades—most notably, state funds provided to districts to remediate students at risk of reading difficulty—are allocated to bubble kids. One cornerstone of this remediation program is a supplementary summer school program for K–2 students who do not meet the state criteria on reading inventories. The explanation of eligibility for this summer program offered by Veronica, a district administrator who controls these grant funds, again highlights that “mak-

ing a difference" for an individual student is understood only as converting a nonpasser to a passer:

If they're not at [the level of proficiency set by the state for each grade level], then they're considered at risk, and they should be referred for summer school. Now, looking at that criter[ion], it's a high criter[ion]. We have to now analyze—I have students below this level, but how below are they? Because it's only a 20-day summer school . . . we have to ask . . . will this 20 days impact a student[s] performance? If I have a student who is maybe just a little bit below those [criteria], that 20 days might make a difference, but if I have someone who's really, really, really below, that 20 days probably wouldn't make a difference.

In a district with a large number of at-risk children, there are many more students who need additional help than to which the district has the resources to attend. This is hardly a new problem in public education. One can argue that this process of educational triage would exist even in the absence of this response to the Texas Accountability System—teachers would still label some kids as "hopeless cases" and teach to those for whom they believe it will "make a difference." One can also contend that, by focusing on "the bubble," teachers are reaching down further than they ever would have before. Certainly, it is impossible to verify to what extent teachers were focusing on students in the bubble score range in the past, because such decisions were unspoken and made by individual teachers. Ironically, in the Brickland district, the policy of catering only to certain students, the very process that the accountability system aimed to eliminate, has been institutionalized vis-à-vis data-driven decision making.

Educational Triage and the Student Success Initiative

One might imagine that requiring all third-grade students to pass the TAKS reading test to be promoted would shift the use of data-driven decision making from institutional to technically rational domains. That is, because schools could not simply create the impression of success by pushing a sufficiently large number of students over the bubble, one might expect them to use these data to address the weakest students' needs throughout the year, as even the students discussed previously as "hopeless cases" would have to pass the test or face retention.

However, because administrators and teachers felt that the numbers that "everyone [would] be looking at" were the percentages of students who passed the test on the first of three potential opportunities, the SSI did not change the way in which this process of educational triage was used.¹⁶ Under the auspices of a data-driven approach, another teacher, Emilia, further defended the school's decision to focus on bubble kids in the third grade:

It's all data driven. The data that comes in, you've got to say based on this data, this is what happened. . . . We do projections—how

many of them do you think will pass, how many of them do you think will need more instruction, how many teachers do we have to work with, what time limit do we have, based on that, who are we going to work with? It comes down to that. . . . We really worked with the bubble kids who we wanted to pass the first time . . . that's the most realistic and time-efficient thing we can think of . . . we're realistic enough to say, "These are the kids we know can do it; get them, and then work with the next group."

In this conception of data-driven practice, such decision making is viewed as neutral and objective. The decision to distribute resources to those most advantageous in regard to aggregate pass rates—the bubble kids—is understood not as a moral or ethical decision but as a sterile management imperative.

Corrina, an administrator at BES, explained the logic of focusing on the bubble kids: "Hopefully what happens on the next test is that the remediation becomes bubbles. The goal is that all of the kids will pass eventually, so we have to keep pulling them up." However, as can be seen in Figure 1, only a small percentage of students in the third grade are in the bubble on any given assessment, while a sizable number remain at the bottom.¹⁷ Notably, special education students who take the state's alternative test are not even given benchmark assessments and thus lose the opportunity to vie for resources in a system dominated by triage; they are, *de facto*, "hopeless cases."

There are two ways in which this system is institutionally, but not technically, rational. First, the lowest-scoring children are given the least attention during the course of the school year. If they ever make it into the bubble, they have increasingly less time to become proficient as the year goes on. A technically rational approach would focus attention on the lowest-scoring students from the very beginning of the school year, with the understanding that they will probably need more time to progress to grade level. Second, that the district established 70% as a passing score for its benchmark tests is notable, because the percentage of questions a third-grade student had to answer cor-

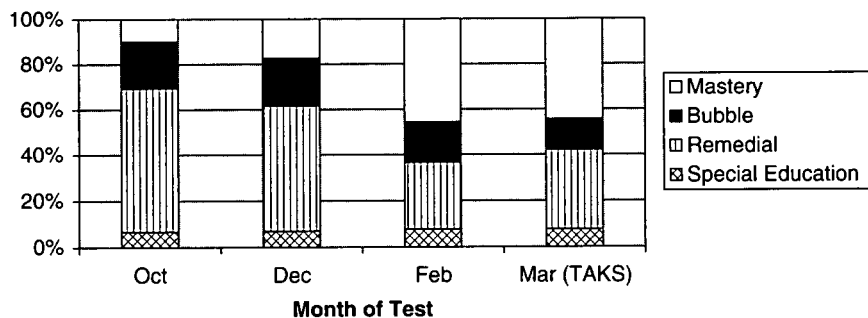


Figure 1. Third-grade scores on reading benchmark tests and first TAKS administration.

rectly to pass the reading test in the 2002–2003 school year was only 55.6%. Choosing to up the state's ante by setting a higher passing requirement, the Brickland district wanted to, in the words of Veronica, "have higher standards for our students than the state." This decision, however, focused attention on students who would have already passed the test.¹⁸ Such a policy follows an institutional logic of action insofar as it provides an insurance policy in the event that students perform less well on the actual TAKS while enabling the district to claim it has higher standards.

Not surprisingly, students who were "below the bubble" for the majority of the school year also failed the first TAKS. Twenty-one students were below the bubble on the February assessment, and 20 of these students failed the test in March. Seventy-four percent of BES students passed the first test. Of the 20 students who failed, 60% were boys. Thirty percent of these students had already been retained once; 42% of the boys who failed had already been retained once. It seems feasible to argue that the data-driven practices at BES actually *produced*, rather than *predicted*, student outcomes.¹⁹

Once BES received the test results at the end of March, third-grade non-passers had only 1 month of intervention before taking the reading test for a second time at the end of April. But even in this month, the bubble concept did not disappear. The bubble was then redefined as students scoring between 45% and 55.6%; now the impetus was to ensure that these students would pass. The state mandated that students who failed the first TAKS receive reduced-class-size instruction (10:1 student-teacher ratio) during the school's literacy block. To meet this requirement, the Brickland district hired local college students to monitor the classrooms of the regular teachers while they left the room to tutor the students who failed (for 1.5 hours each day). The teacher assigned "seat work," work that did not require assistance from a teacher and that could be completed silently, to the other students for this time period. All four of the third-grade teachers were opposed to this policy because they felt that inordinate resources were being devoted to a "small number of students," despite the fact that this very practice had been engaged in throughout the year in regard to the focus on bubble kids. As one teacher explained:

My thing is that the kids who failed shouldn't take the time away from the other kids. They failed because they weren't ready, and they weren't going to be ready. I would have retained them anyway. Out of the four [in my class] who failed, three of them should have been retained in second [grade]. There's just too much emphasis put on these kids who failed and it's taking time away from everything else.

Their ability to decry the differential allocation of resources to one group of students despite engaging in this practice all year is grounded in teachers' understanding of data-driven decisions as neutral and objective. In contrast to this "neutrality," the state's mandate to divert resources to the students who failed was seen as a transparent and direct decision to focus on one group of students over the other.

As discussed previously, 20 students failed the third-grade reading test and an additional 2 were absent, requiring a total of 22 students to retake the test. In the month before the second reading test, 1 student was classified as a special education student, a phenomenon detailed later in this article. Of the 21 remaining students, 14 were identified as bubble kids. On the second test, 13 of these 14 bubble kids passed. Of the 8 students who failed the second test, 7 were boys and 4 had already been retained once. While only 1 student in the third grade did not pass the reading test after three attempts, 7 third-grade students were retained (including the student who did not pass the test), despite 6 of these 7 students passing the final test. All 6 of these students were boys, 3 of whom had already been retained once previously.

Although the institutional logic of educational triage still guided BES's response to the SSI, in some respects the SSI interrupted these practices. The school legally had to provide supplementary services to those students who failed the TAKS. In a regular year, these students would have failed and received no remediation. BES used triage in an alternative way as well; during the final 3 months of school, the third-grade students who failed became the urgent cases. Whether these students would have been better off receiving additional attention throughout the year is an open question, and one that this article cannot address. However, as with those students who became "non-urgent cases" after the first test, the remainder of the third-grade students did "seat work" while their teachers left the room to tutor students. Special education students, who did not have to pass the test to be promoted, moved even further into the background. Moreover, the attention of all of the support staff in the school—the literacy teacher, the instructional facilitator, and the counselor, among others—was focused on these third-grade students. Each of these support teachers relayed to me that the needs of students in other grades were being ignored to attend to the crisis at hand. In their more anxious moments, they lamented that they did not know what the school would do in 2005 when third- and fifth-grade students had to pass TAKS tests to be promoted. There simply would not be anywhere else to "take" from.

Getting "the Numbers We Need": "Accountables"

They want that kid out so they can have one less accountable—you've probably heard that word a lot around here—so . . . they'd have 19 accountables to worry about instead of 20.—Lorraine (a teacher)

The process of triage does not end with the diversion of resources to the bubble kids. In the Texas Accountability System, all students are not equally valuable to the school's rating. That each school has an "accountability subset"—those students who "count" in a school's accountability rating—creates an incentive for teachers to focus on "accountable students." In 2003, the accountability subset excluded special education students taking the state's alternative test (the State Developed Alternative Assessment, or

"Educational Triage" and the Texas Accountability System

SDAA), students who had moved into the district after a state-determined date at the end of October, special education and English-language learners exempted by the school, and absent students. Using an institutional rather than a technically rational approach, teachers enact a second component of educational triage by focusing on the "accountables" and attempting to remove potentially low-scoring students from the accountability subset by having these students tested to determine whether they qualified for special education. The following excerpt from a grade-level planning meeting reveals how focusing on the bubble kids and the "accountables" worked in tandem:

Corrina: Count up and see if we have the numbers that we need.

David: This kid is not accountable. Do I even need to worry about him?

Corrina: No . . . don't worry about him.

Phyllis: I have 16. I need [student's name]. I need to pull another one. If I can just pull him . . . these two for sure will pass . . . he should . . . all those 60s, I'm saying they're going to pass. If I count all my 50s and stuff, then. . . .

The purported purpose of these planning sessions—to evaluate the progress of each student—belies their real function, which is to evaluate how close the grade level is to attaining "the numbers we need." In the case of BES, striving toward a "recognized" rating, the goal was 80%. In this inventory, nonaccountable students were, by the direction of Corrina (one of the administrators responsible for testing), labeled as students whose academic progress teachers do not have to "worry" about. When I later asked Phyllis who the "nonaccountables" were, she offered the technical response of those who "came in after the October 'snapshot date.'" She then commented, "That definitely helps, you know, not having their scores count."

What none of these teachers and administrators discussed, however, was that the 2002–2003 school year was designated a "nonaccountable" year by the TEA. Because of the implementation of the new testing system, schools would maintain their rating from the previous year. That it was not an "accountable" year did not alter the way the school functioned, as teachers and administrators relayed that the scores would "still be in the newspaper" and the district would be "looking at those scores." Because of the intersection of teachers' class scores and their evaluations of their own professional competence, the official assignment of a rating to the school almost became redundant.

Another teacher, Sofia, explained that she had only a small number of accountables in her class that year (11 of 21 students), so each accountable student would represent about 9% of her class's scores. For this reason, the usual strategy of tutoring only the bubble kids was slightly altered: "I set it up this way. I only tutor the accountable students on Tuesday, Wednesday, and Thursday and it's mandatory for them. All of the accountables have to come." The other 10 students in her class were, in her words, "put on the back burner." The low number of accountable students in her class mediated the focus on the bubble to some extent, although one form of triage was essentially replaced with another. A phone call she received from Corrina (an administrator) dur-

ing my interview, about a student possibly missing school on the day of the test because of a doctor's appointment, exhibits this substitution:

Sofia: Hello. . . . No, it doesn't really matter if she's here or not.

[pause]

Sofia: No, she's a nonaccountable, so I'm not . . . I'm not worried . . . she may make it, but it doesn't really matter because she doesn't count in our accountables either way.

These "nonaccountables" do not represent a small percentage of the student population. Approximately 80% of students in Grades 3–5 at BES are part of the accountability subset. Approximately 5% of the remaining group of non-accountable students are mobile students, while the other 15% are tested solely on the SDAA.

The Struggle Over Special Education Classifications

Perhaps the most disadvantaged by this system of triage are students classified as special education students. At BES, the overwhelming majority of these students take the state's alternative assessment (the SDAA). In the third grade, only one special education student took any of the three reading benchmark exams, and he took only the October test. After he scored a 29 on this first test, his admission, review, and dismissal committee decided that he would take the SDAA. Not only are these "nonaccountable" special education students denied the opportunity to compete for resources in the triage system, their exclusion from the benchmark tests precludes any consideration of their needs in planning full class instruction through the 9-week planning process. Their complete absence from the roster that each teacher brings into these planning sessions reflects how invisible these students have become in both the classroom and the school.²⁰

According to the special education teachers at BES, the accountability system has dramatically affected the frequency of special education referrals. Roslyn, a special education teacher, stated:

[The testing has] definitely increased the number of referrals. Some teachers are really jumping the gun. . . . These teachers need to understand that just because a kid is behind doesn't mean they are special ed, and these teachers don't seem to understand that. . . . These teachers want to refer everyone who is not going to pass the TAKS, and we have to say no a lot of times. Because once you put a kid in special ed, that label is hard to get off . . . the teachers aren't accountable for those scores so they don't feel responsible for these kids. They're pushing them to the side, and some teachers tell me that directly. They actually tell me that since the kids aren't accountable, they're not worrying about them.

Her comment that the "label" of special education is hard to remove speaks to the crucial difference between educational triage that focuses on bubble

kids and triage that attempts to eliminate a student from the accountability subset. The "remedial" label, as harmful as it is, has the potential to be temporary, while the label resulting from special education testing has the potential to permanently alter a student's educational trajectory.

Reviews of third-grade students' intervention folders corroborated the assertion that teachers were referring students for special education testing in response to the TAKS. Many of the third graders were tested for special education or were recommended for testing in second grade specifically because the teacher believed that they would not pass the test. Multiple comments in students' intervention folders illustrated this process; one such comment was as follows: "Recommended student be tested now, has been retained once. Student will have to be placed next year. Will not be able to pass TAKS at this level." With the increase in referrals, the percentage of students enrolled in special education at BES has doubled since the implementation of the accountability system.

Interestingly, the school's principal, Marguerite, opposed the increased number of special education referrals and the fact that a high number of students were taking the SDAA instead of the TAKS. Earlier in the year, she had created more stringent requirements for teachers who wanted to have students tested for special education, requiring more documentation before the process could begin. In a memo to teachers, she wrote:

Teachers, please be aware that in order to refer a student for special education assessments (learning disability, psychological, and/or speech), there must be *an educational need*. You must be able to demonstrate that the disability is such that the child is unable to learn.

According to Marguerite, her strong stance against excluding students with learning disabilities from taking the TAKS often creates friction between her and the teachers. In spite of her efforts to minimize the number of students taking the SDAA, almost all special education students at BES took this test. Diverging from contentions that principals and special education teachers drive increasing special education classifications, the experience of BES suggests that some other mechanism may account for this dynamic.

Ability as Fixed and Generalizable: DNQs

Even if students referred for testing do not qualify for special education, the dominant understanding of the "DNQ" designation can shape teachers' perceptions of them as well. After referral to special education in the Brickland district, a student is given both an achievement test and an IQ test.²¹ If one standard deviation exists between a student's achievement and IQ—that is, she or he is not achieving to her or his "potential"—the student qualifies for special education services.²² Teachers and administrators use the shorthand "DNQ" for students whose IQs are commensurate with their achievement: They "do not qualify" for special education. While failure to qualify for special

education has the potential to refocus attention on a "low-performing" student, given that she or he would still affect the school's accountability rating, the district-wide understanding of what it means to be a "DNQ" leads to a different yet equally stigmatizing label for these students.

Teachers and administrators often expressed concern that it was unfair to require these DNQs, who are "doing the best they can," to pass the TAKS in order to be promoted. Yet, in expressing this concern, they exposed their beliefs about ability as a fixed potential that cannot be transcended. As a district administrator, Carmela, explained:

You have one set of children I haven't quite figured out what the world's going to do with. They don't qualify for special ed. It's the ones that you put in a special ed packet and the special ed people will say, "According to their IQ, they're doing the best they can." The best they can is five questions. And you're saying, I don't think they're ever going to get there. I don't know—no one has ever answered for me, what are we going to do with those? And I think, if I have a bias against the state test, it would be for those group of people. Because they don't qualify for this test, they sure can't do that test, and I think that maybe we ought to have a middle ground for them.

The understanding that DNQs are "working at their capacity" exonerates the school or teacher of responsibility for these students' low performance. In the case of the DNQs themselves, being tested for special education, a process that is intended to identify learning difficulties and thus provide a road map for remediation, instead serves to solidify notions of their inability to achieve. Teachers saw typical interventions as futile for DNQs, who were essentially viewed as "slow." As Luis explained:

I believe in holding kids back. I don't believe in social promotion. But one of these kids is a DNQ—she has an IQ of 70 and she's performing at the highest level that she can. She's *never* going to be able to read at a high level and she won't pass the TAKS. So why hold her back?

As evidenced by his assumption that this student's reading ability will never change, essentially DNQs are relegated to the status of "hopeless cases." I do not hold that these conceptions of ability are a function of the accountability system. The DNQ designation, in fact, predated this system. However, because of the push to remove more and more students from the accountability subset, a much larger number of students are being tested, and, as a result, a larger number of students are labeled DNQ.

The positioning of DNQs as unsuitable for intervention, in conjunction with the practice of focusing on the bubble kids, targeting resources to the accountables, and decreasing the size of the accountability subset through special education classification, completes BES's constellation of educational triage practices. Taken together, they represent BES's response to the Texas

Accountability System—a response that, it should be noted, would be deemed “acceptable” in its eyes.

A simple explanation of the data reported in this article could be that these teachers were not particularly committed to teaching “other people’s children” (Delpit, 1995) and harbored low expectations for their performance. However, as is the case with the majority of individuals who choose to teach, teachers at BES expressed a strong commitment to children, particularly poor, minority children. Comments such as the following were commonplace in interviews with teachers:

I love to work with these kids. I could easily work in [a more affluent district], but I tell my husband, “I like these kids.” I want to work where the need is there. And I think the need is here. (Emilia)

I will take a child wherever they will let me take him or her. . . . I really don’t want to leave any child behind. (Holly)

One could argue that these teachers solely “talk the talk” and do not follow through with their actions. To the contrary, the overwhelming majority of teachers exhibited their willingness to “go the extra mile” for children (Bryk & Schneider, 2002, p. 22). For example, Emilia stayed after school to tutor students for 2 hours each day throughout the entire school year. She, like almost all of the teachers in the TAKS-tested grades (3–5), came to the school on Saturdays throughout the year to tutor students. She called their homes on Friday nights to remind students to attend and offered to pick them up at home if they did not have a ride to these Saturday sessions. Yet, as described earlier, this labor was directed toward the bubble kids.

An explanation of teachers’ willingness to focus their attention on bubble kids, then, cannot locate the problem as existing within the lack of commitment of individual teachers; one is left asking why teachers committed to their students would acquiesce to the district’s policy of educational triage. Thus, I turn my attention to how the public release of teachers’ class scores endangers teacher-teacher relationships by shaping the way in which teachers feel about themselves and each other.

Endangering Relational Trust: Teacher-Teacher Relationships

As discussed earlier, I found Bryk and Schneider’s (2002) work on relational trust most helpful in understanding the strained relationships between teachers at BES and the consequences that might flow forth from these dynamics. One of Bryk and Schneider’s key insights is the way in which the presence of relational trust maintains a steady focus on the central goal of the school: to educate all children. Accordingly, Bryk and Schneider wrote, “In the context of schooling, when all is said and done, actions must be understood as about advancing the best interests of children” (p. 26). In this respect, relational trust serves as a “moral resource for action” (p. 26).

Whether and how this potent moral resource for action is affected by Brickland's response to the accountability system is, then, the crucial question here.²³ Along these lines, Bryk and Schneider (2002) reminded us:

While most discussions in education policy today focus on the technical dimensions of teaching and its enhancement, that teachers' humanness is very much a part of their practice is important to remember, and teachers need expressions of personal regard and support as much as anyone else does. (p. 27)

Teachers want to be appreciated for the hard work they do and recognized as "good teachers." The desire to be viewed as a good teacher is not simply hedonistic. Teachers want to know that they are effective in helping the children they teach. But given the multiple ends of schooling, good teaching has historically been difficult for external parties to gauge. As the Brickland district has reduced "good" teaching to the percentage of students passing benchmark and TAKS tests, a common metric has been developed that allows for comparisons of teachers' competence within and across grades. Consequently, the public release of individual teachers' aggregate class scores and teachers' understandings of the purpose of this practice engendered a competitive environment within the confines of the school. In addition to fear of judgment by their peers, teachers were motivated by ideas circulated about "good" and "bad" teachers that served to construct the quality of a teacher as a function of her or his students' test scores. Administrators noted the ways in which teachers made a connection between their students' scores and their competence. As Mary explained:

I see these teachers getting so stressed out about these tests. I just keep trying to explain to these teachers, or try to help them out . . . this is an assessment. We need to find out, not that you're a good teacher or not, but whether the curriculum is helping the students when it comes test time. I think that a lot of them take it real personally, that . . . I'm a bad teacher. My students didn't do well.

Thus, teachers' fears of being branded "a bad teacher"—by both their colleagues and themselves—drive the effort to focus more attention on the bubble kids and pull more students into the "passing" range. In fact, all of the teachers interviewed talked about the intense pressure they felt to increase their students' scores. Most spoke about this pressure as the most significant impact of the tests on their classroom. According to Noreen: "The impact of this test is fear—for everybody, teachers and students. Everyone feels like they work all year just to pass this test."

The majority of teachers, in discussing this pressure, spoke emotionally about an annual faculty meeting at which a chart was revealed listing each teacher's pass rate next to his or her name. Some of the teachers focused

their comments on the negative self-valuations that resulted from their students' poor scores. For example, Alene stated:

[Last year] I was so upset when their scores came back. They did real good on reading, but only 55% of my kids passed the math. And we went to this faculty meeting and they put every teacher's scores and pass rates up on the transparency, and I just wanted to cry. I felt so bad, like I had done something wrong, like I was a bad teacher.

Other teachers emphasized that their colleagues make judgments about their professional competence on the basis of these scores. According to Hector:

Everything rides on it [the test]. . . . You can't be a teacher who deviates from the average—you know, the average for the school. They pass out this paper with everyone's scores and they put your scores up on a transparency, so if you're on the lower side, people think you're a terrible teacher and you're doing something wrong, and if you're on the higher side, everyone says, "Oooo, he's doing something right." The thing is, even if you are a terrible teacher and you get high scores, that's all that matters.

Finally, other teachers simply expressed outrage that this practice occurred. Esmeralda tensely shared:

I guess they're trying to humiliate us into getting their scores up. . . . It's all accountability, accountability, accountability. Why don't they just strip you naked and make you stand on a table? That's the same thing as putting your scores up there.

As these excerpts demonstrate, the practice of publicly reporting each teacher's scores creates a remarkable amount of anxiety. Teachers anguish that their colleagues judge their professional competence on the basis of their students' scores while at the same time making judgments about the competence of their peers—a dynamic that endangers relational trust. Somewhat surprisingly, teachers rarely revealed concern about the role of their students' test scores in their formal evaluation by the principal. In fact, Marguerite advocated that teachers spend less time worrying about test scores:

I've told the teachers that we need to do what best teaching practice is. You know, set aside the test. If they're doing what they know is best for the students, then the test should take care of itself. But there's a lot of stress and anxiety that comes in, and so the teachers feel like they have to teach toward the test instead of teaching the child and teaching what's best. . . . I see anxiety levels going extremely high.

Although she felt that she made a concerted effort to reduce teacher anxiety, the school's participation in the district-wide practice of making teachers' class pass rates public overshadowed her efforts.

Teachers' concerns about being embarrassed in front of their peers and subsequently devalued were well founded. Many teachers, in discussing the infamous transparency, also commented on their colleagues' performance. In the words of Milagros:

At the end of the year, they have a meeting and they put a transparency up with everyone's class average on it. And the teachers talk. One teacher—she stayed with her class for 2 years and she had the lowest scores last year.

Returning to the public posting of class pass rates, teachers condemned the policy because the inadequate achievement level of some of the students entering their classrooms had already crippled them. Here an important shift occurs in this system focused on increasing the percentage of students passing a test rather than on enhancing individual growth. When a low-performing student enters a teacher's classroom, she or he represents a liability rather than an opportunity to promote individual growth. The emphasis shifts "from student needs to student performance and from what the school does for the student to what the student does for the school" (Apple, 2001, p. 71).

In the high-anxiety environment created by the release of individual teachers' scores, teachers were incredibly vigilant about the role other teachers played in preparing their students. Experiences with poorly prepared students led teachers to doubt their colleagues' competence. Moreover, they doubted their integrity, questioning their colleagues' allegiance to the school's mission to improve test scores. Tellingly, teachers' complaints were not framed in terms of their colleagues' failure to act in the best interests of children. Instead, teachers focused on the ways in which other teachers made the job of ensuring that students pass the TAKS more difficult.

Teachers tended to deride the teachers in the grades under them for promoting students who "weren't ready" or for failing to prepare them properly. Marsha, somewhat taken aback by her colleagues' effrontery, recounted an exchange with two teachers in the grade above her in which they questioned her judgment in promoting a number of students:

[Two teachers] came to me and said, "What were you thinking when you moved them up?" If they'd just look at their PRCs [permanent record cards] they'd see that I placed them in the next grade. I didn't promote them. They should know that I didn't have a choice. They'd already been retained once between kindergarten and third grade. It creates a lot of tension.²⁴

Certainly teachers have perennially complained about the preparation of their students, but with the onset of an internal system of competition that

conditions how teachers see each other and themselves, these complaints reached a fever pitch. An issue previously relegated to fodder for faculty room gossip became a serious strain on relationships.

Similarly, many teachers in Grades 3 through 5 lamented that the lower grades (K–2) were not "accountable enough" because lower-grade students were not tested by the state. This created a schism between the K–2 and 3–5 teachers. The upper-grade teachers often felt that the lower-grade teachers left the task of preparing students for the TAKS solely to them, as this excerpt from my field notes demonstrates:

Carolina and I are standing in the hallway talking as a [lower-grade class] approaches. The students are returning from lunch, and boisterously talk and push each other out of line. Carolina scowls and then says to me in a lowered voice, "You need to go to see the [previous] grade because it's playtime down there—and how am I going to get those kids up to speed for the TAKS if that's what's coming up to me? If you go . . . downstairs and you look at the bulletin boards, it's all this cutesy artsy-crafty stuff. I don't see any writing or any kind of, not even letter formations out there. It's just putting your hand-print on and making butterfly rings and stuff. I really don't think that they do prepare them that much."

Teachers in the lower grades, however, reported feeling "just as much pressure as the upper grades" to increase their scores. Their actions reflected their desire to increase their students' test scores. For example, some teachers in these grades decided to reduce their classes' recess to 15 minutes per week to provide more time for academic instruction. Their colleagues felt pressure to eliminate recess as well and were resentful of their colleagues' decision, as they believed that it forced their hand. A handful of teachers flouted this decision. As Esmeralda described:

We only have recess one day a week for 15 minutes. You can't be caught out there. Oooo—I'm not sure what would happen. These people don't understand child development. I wonder if they ever went to college. Where are they getting their ideas from? They think we shouldn't have recess because we should focus on academics. This year I said, forget it, there's no way I can teach these kids if they don't have a break, so I've been taking them out.

Lower grade teachers, too, blamed teachers in the grades below them for failing to prepare students. In addition, they often spoke with reserved contempt about the need for parents to be accountable in preparing their children and supporting their education. With their own professional competence on the line (not only in the eyes of their colleagues, but in their own), teachers allocated blame for unprepared students to teachers at the preceding grade levels or to parents. In making such judgments of their colleagues, teachers reinforce for themselves that there is a relationship between

their competence as teachers and their classes' scores. They understand their students' performance as a reflection of their own teaching ability, and the pressure on them to improve scores derives from the possibility of negative self-valuation. Such self-valuations are important in that they shape the ways in which teachers interact with their colleagues, in terms of both their respect for them as partners in the development of students and their willingness to extend personal concern to them.

Furthermore, because the scores for Grades 3–5 are aggregated to achieve ratings, teachers did not want to endanger their school's chance of achieving a "recognized" rating. This rating, which teachers felt served as a proxy of the quality of every teacher in the school, also related to the formation of teachers' identities as "good" or "bad" teachers. Teachers censured the practice of judging the quality of a school according to such ratings; simultaneously, however, the ratings affected their self-perceptions. According to Edie:

It does make me upset because people will say "Oh, look, that's a recognized school—that's a good school, those are good teachers." And so we feel like if we're not a recognized school, we're not a good school, and then that means we're not good teachers. People don't look past that label. And the district is into that too. The principal has to go to a meeting and they'll put all of the schools up on a board, in order of how many kids passed. Then [the principal] has to come back to our school and give us that data—usually, everyone will go into that meeting like normal—you know, talking and happy—and people will come out totally quiet. Because we feel terrible that our school is near the bottom.

Again, the feeling that the rating is a reflection of the ability of every teacher in the school drives the push to increase scores. In this context, the extent to which teachers perceive that their colleagues are willing and able to contribute to the school's achievement of a "recognized" rating dominates their judgments of their colleagues' competence and integrity.

The salience of this rating, and its connection to the self-valuations of teachers, was most poignantly demonstrated at the pep rally for the TAKS held the day before the April tests began. After a series of deafening chants of "I can pass the test!" and a short pep talk by Marguerite, Marguerite called one of the teachers, Noreen, to the stage. Taking the microphone, Noreen said, "This is really for all of the teachers here. This poem is called 'TAKS: What a Word!'" The students in the class sitting in front of me bobbed their heads from side to side, looking perplexed as to why the teachers needed a pep talk. After all, they were not the ones taking the tests. Noreen then read her poem, an excerpt of which follows:

What a wonderful feeling it is for me,
To be a small part of what my children are going to be.
To know that I worked with all my heart and my soul,
This is what is important, I don't need to be told[. . .]

"Educational Triage" and the Texas Accountability System

Our scores will go up, we'll all make the grade,
We'll do it together, so don't be afraid.
And when the recognized schools are called,
Because of what they achieved,
Beck will be there, so proud,
Because we all believed!

As Noreen connected the emotive issue that these teachers lived with every day—their desire to help their students succeed, coupled with their gnawing fears that they wouldn't "make the grade"—teachers reacted in two different ways. As I recorded in my field notes:

As I look around the room, some of the teachers look visibly uncomfortable, and have turned their eyes to the floor. Others are shifting around in their seats. But there is also another reaction—a few of the teachers seem elated that Noreen has made public the tension that they live with so privately each day. When Noreen finishes the poem, she exits the stage, and the focus of the pep rally turns back to the students. . . . No one mentions the poem, or the themes that it unveils, for the balance of the day.

The desire to achieve a "recognized" rating existed somewhat in contradiction to each teacher's desire for her or his own class to remain above the average pass rate for the faculty. The existence of this tension—teachers' longing for collective success alongside the hope for their peers' performance to be less noteworthy than their own—put a very real strain on teachers' relationships with each other and on the school as a community.

When each teacher competes as an individual, the idea of a professional community becomes endangered. The primacy of internal competition trumped the community building that could have been engendered by the aggregation of the school's scores in the rating system. This collective rating instead became its own source of acrimony, with some teachers feeling that others were not "carrying their weight." The following exchange in a team meeting of teachers illustrates this embitterment:

- Juana:* Guys, I really don't think the [grade level above] is doing very much.
Adrianna: Of course we're left carrying the school—again. I mean, look, we got the reading scores up.
Sberry: Yeah, we're carrying these kids—the whole grade—on our own backs.

In this moment of solidarity, these teachers view themselves as a team, albeit only in contrast to another group of teachers they perceive to be performing at a lower level. Such coalitions were fleeting. At other points in the study, each of these teachers critiqued the competence or integrity of the other teachers on their team. Team meetings, in addition to serving as a potential opportunity for coalition, often erupted in disagreement. In one team meeting, a teacher took

serious offense at another teacher's suggestion that the reason BES had not achieved a "recognized" rating was teachers' low expectations. My notes from the meeting included the following:

As the teachers discuss the success of another elementary school in the district that has been rated "exemplary" for several years, the atmosphere of the meeting becomes tense. Benita then says, "BES still hasn't been 'recognized.' We need to look at everything and try to improve. We haven't been up there. We are going to have to have higher expectations now." Daniela's face clouds over, her tone changing, as she says, "I'm sorry! I have always had high expectations for my students! It has been done."

The sense that individual teachers felt blamed for the school's performance pervaded this meeting. In a school where teachers see each other as partners rather than competitors, this statement might be taken as an effort to rally and unite teachers in collective support for reform. Here, instead, it was viewed as an attack on the integrity of the teachers at BES.

An interesting contradiction emerges in the data reported in this section. On one hand, no teacher interviewed contested the legitimacy of the focus on the bubble kids or criticized her or his colleagues for engaging in this practice. On the other hand, teachers vigorously complained when they felt that their colleagues did not adequately prepare particular students in the grades below them. Essentially, this complaint charged that teachers did not adequately raise the skill level of the lowest-performing students. Yet, the practice of focusing on the bubble kids involved the same practices and ensured the same result: Those students who never made it into the bubble did not receive the extra attention they needed and remained low performing as they moved to the next grade.

How, then, can one account for this disjuncture in teachers' attitudes? As the practice of focusing attention on bubble kids is based on data, teachers feel that it is a neutral and objective enterprise. Protected by its scientific underpinnings, the focus on bubble kids proved more difficult for teachers to attack. Colleagues remained a much easier target, in that seeds of distrust had already been planted by competition. In summary, teachers' beliefs in data's neutrality operate in conjunction with teachers' scapegoating of students' low performance. Taken together, these dynamics insulate the practice of focusing attention on bubble kids from scrutiny.

Discussion

This article illustrates that an institutional logic of action guided both the Brickland district's and individual teachers' responses to the Texas Accountability System. The district as well as its teachers sought to create the appearance of goal attainment, that is, providing a better education for all students. By maneuvering through the loopholes left open by the TEA—the exclusion of mobile students and special education students taking the SDAA from the

accountability subset—the Brickland district and its teachers sought to create the impression, if not the reality, of improvement.

Yet, unlike exploitation of the loopholes just described, the centerpiece of the district's response—data-driven decision making—presents an interesting case in the context of the institutional literature. While adopting such a system provides the district with legitimacy in the eyes of external parties, its internal functioning can be altered to correspond with institutional or technically rational logics (Riehl, 1999). This system can be used to monitor and support the individual growth of each student, regardless of his or her potential contribution to a school's outcomes. At the same time, it can be used to remove low-scoring students from the accountability subset and to focus attention on those students most likely to assist in improving the performance of the school: the bubble kids. As one reviewer pointed out, it is possible that the dynamics I observed resulted from BES's position as a "bubble school" on the cusp of attaining a "recognized" rating. Similarly, although not captured in this cross-sectional study, a longitudinal study of BES would probably reveal that teachers use data-driven decision making in different ways depending on their previous performance, the composition of their class, and their evaluations of their own ability to achieve the necessary results without using educational triage practices. In sum, depending on contextual factors, institutionally or technically rational uses of data-driven decision making may vary. In the Brickland context, however, the effectiveness of data-driven decision making as a rationalized myth derived precisely from its protean nature—its ability to morph in district and teacher discourse between institutional and technically rational domains.

That an institutional logic of action dominated teachers' responses to the Texas Accountability System explains *how*, but not *why*, teachers acquiesced to the district policy of data-driven decision making. Their willingness to participate in these practices is particularly notable in light of the body of research documenting teachers' reticence in regard to implementing programs and policies mandated from above. I found that the institutional environment, in defining a good teacher as one who increases her or his students' scores, shaped teachers' ideas about what it meant to be a "good" or a "bad" teacher. The district's decision to publicly release teachers' scores, which can be seen as a response to the institutional environment, further reinforced the notion that the sole measure of good teaching is the attainment of high pass rates. Any other measure of "good teaching" was displaced. Consequently, teachers sought to be recognized as "good teachers" by using an institutional logic—or, concretely, a series of educational triage practices—to increase students' scores. The flexibility of the rationalized myth of data-driven decision making served to neutralize and legitimate these educational triage practices.

However, the existence of a salient rationalized myth, as well as the institutional environment's foray into teacher professional identities, still fails to explain why teachers did not act collectively to resist these incursions into their practice, as would be predicted by the faculty workplace literature (Bid-

well, 2001; McLaughlin & Talbert, 2001; Talbert & McLaughlin, 1994). By implementing a system that individualized teacher performance rather than engendering a sentiment of collective responsibility for all students, the Brickland district fundamentally shaped the quality of relationships possible between teachers. Each teacher acted as an atomized unit and adopted practices that increased her or his currency as a "good" teacher. The institutional environment, by shaping teachers' professional identities as "good" or "bad" teachers and influencing the district's decision to individualize teacher performance via data-driven decision making, mediated teachers' abilities to form and sustain collegial relationships. Putting teachers into competition with one another led teachers to see their colleagues as threats rather than partners, which inhibited the adaptive capacity of faculty networks described in previous literature. In sum, such dynamics affected the faculty's ability to work together toward a common goal.

At the level of the organization, a number of important consequences derived from these foundering relationships. The singular focus on increasing aggregate test scores rendered school-wide discussion of the "best interests of children" obsolete. The moral-ethical perspective of educators (Bryk & Schneider, 2002, p. 26) was supplanted by an instrumental concern for moving a designated number of "accountable" children above a particular bar. In the Brickland district's system, it is individually irrational for a teacher to focus her or his time and attention on students who may not move above this bar in any given year or who do not "count." Because of the ways in which the individualization inherent in this system undermined teacher-teacher relationships, no imperative could develop at the level of the community to counterbalance the individual irrationality of focusing on the lowest-performing or "nonaccountable" students. The potential casualty of the push to increase scores is not only the quality of social relationships possible between teachers—"a valued outcome in [its] own right" (Bryk & Schneider, 2002, p. 19)—but the ability of BES to act as a collective agent protecting the "best interests" of all children.

Conclusion

Whether teachers reacting to the NCLB legislation will adopt educational triage practices to improve their schools' scores remains an open question. The findings presented in this article indicate that future research should pay close attention to the structure of NCLB state implementation plans. Embedded within these plans are differential incentives and disincentives for focusing on some students rather than others. The unique features of these systems across states are likely to shape the nature of schools' and teachers' responses. At present, the Texas Accountability System is not entirely aligned with NCLB, and it is unclear which system will drive districts', schools', and teachers' behavior. Texas has attempted to maintain a separate special education test and average these results with regular TAKS tests for Grades 3–8. However, the U.S. Department of Education recently determined that no more than 1% of Texas

students can be tested on an alternative assessment. Nonetheless, Texas Education Commissioner Shirley Neeley flouted this directive, refusing to rate schools as "in need of improvement" for allowing more than 1% of students to take the SDAA. As this article goes to press, it is still unclear how Secretary of Education Margaret Spellings will handle this inconsistency.

Texas has also created two different guidelines in regard to subgroup sizes. Under the state system, subgroups must include at least 30 students and represent at least 10% of all students or include 50 or more students to be evaluated; under the Texas NCLB implementation plan, subgroups must include at least 50 students and represent at least 10% of all students or include 200 or more students to be evaluated (TEA, 2004b). Moreover, adequate yearly progress will not be calculated for all students present at a school at the time of the test. Expanding on the definition of mobile "nonaccountable" students discussed here, TEA has eliminated even more mobile students from schools' accountability subsets. Students who move to another school within the *same* district after October of a given school year will not count in the school's adequate yearly progress determinations (TEA, 2004a). In high mobility areas, this provision will result in significant numbers of students not being counted at the school level. In sum, if states' responses to NCLB are structured in ways that exclude some students from "counting," it is more probable that schools will use various forms of educational triage to create the illusion of increased scores.

Regardless of the structure of a given state's response to NCLB, the current popularity enjoyed by data-driven decision making is unlikely to dissipate. At the core of the educational triage practices used at BES is a deference to data—which are understood solely as quantitative outcomes on multiple-choice, or "TAKS-formatted," tests—and their neutrality and objectivity. In the recent educational literature, data are treated as an unquestionably positive force. Certainly, one can imagine uses of data that would focus attention on the individual needs of each and every student. The results of this study, however, demonstrate the need to infuse this literature with an understanding that data can also be used to target some students at the expense of others. In presenting these findings, I hope to reorient this discussion, emphasizing that decisions about resource allocation are ethical decisions with which educators and communities must grapple and for which they must ultimately take responsibility. The question of how scarce resources should be allocated strikes at the heart of the inherent tensions surrounding public education in a stratified society and must be addressed in public, not technical, arenas.

Notes

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¹All names are pseudonyms.

²In the 2002–2003 school year, only third-grade students were required to pass the TAKS reading test to be promoted. In addition, this third-grade cohort is the first required to pass math and reading tests to be promoted when they reach the fifth and eighth grades.

³Each school has an “accountability subset”—the group of students whose test scores determine the school’s rating. At the time of this study, the accountability subset excluded special education students taking the state’s alternative test, students moving into the district after a state-determined date at the end of October, absent students, and children with limited English proficiency or special education designations for whom teachers do not feel the test is an appropriate measure (TEA, 2002). In the 2003–2004 school year, the TEA began to incorporate SDAA scores into the accountability rating; the Admission, Review, and Dismissal Committee sets the passing expectations for each student (TEA, 2004a).

⁴Beginning in 1993, Texas administered the reading and math portions of the Texas Assessment of Academic Skills (TAAS) to students in Grades 3–8 and 10 and the writing portion to students in Grades 4, 8, and 10. Science and social studies tests were added in later years. In addition, TEA began to disaggregate student results by race, ethnicity, and socioeconomic status. All subgroups would be required to pass at the prescribed rate for a school to achieve a particular rating (TEA, 2003c).

⁵Bryk and Schneider focused on the role relationships among administrators, teachers, and parents; in this article, however, the framework is used only to examine teacher-teacher relationships.

⁶In selecting a case study school, I first identified districts with a mostly minority and poor population (more than 75% minority and low socioeconomic status) within a metropolitan area chosen for reasons of convenience. Two districts meeting these criteria were identified as possible study locations. I chose the higher performing district of this group; using data provided by TEA’s Academic Excellence Indicator System reports, I then identified elementary schools within this district that had aggregate scores between 75% and 85% across subjects. I eliminated dual-language schools and schools with suspicious exemption patterns that made them possible outliers. I did not want to seek out schools that seemed to be “gaming” the system. At this point, I gained permission from the principal of BES to conduct research there.

⁷Despite the fact that the 2002–2003 school year was an “unrated” year—campuses were not assigned ratings because the TAKS tests were taken for the first time—BES and Brickland educators still spoke about ratings in the terms of the old system.

⁸Two teachers were persistently absent or unavailable during the time I spent at BES; hence, I was unable to interview these teachers.

⁹These plans, created four times a year by all teachers at a given grade level, set targets for the number of students passing the next practice test given by the district.

¹⁰The most well-known model is often called the “Brazosport model,” named for the school district in which it first became prominent. The eight-step model is described by former Superintendent Gerald Anderson as a marriage of “total quality management” principles and the effective schools literature (Cook, 2003, p. 25).

¹¹For example, according to a training module on the TEA’s Web site, “Wise and reasoned decision-making about education issues is based on the careful analysis of a wide range of data. Data help responsible educators do two things: to understand students’ needs and to plan for student academic achievement and success. . . . Data-driven decision making improves classroom practice” (TEA, 2003e).

¹²When I use the term “data-driven decision making,” I am referring to the way in which teachers at BES are using this practice. It is important to note from the outset that my purpose is not to indict the broader concept of using data to make educational decisions. Instead, I intend to demonstrate the way that “data-driven” practices are being implemented on a day-to-day basis at BES.

¹³In an effort to ascertain the curriculum objectives with which students were struggling, the district’s test creators marked each test question as assessing one of the objectives in the state standards. For example, there are four objectives for reading in Texas; each question, then, tested one of these four objectives.

¹⁴Together, these teachers also decide which objectives are proving most difficult for the majority of students in the grade and formulate a plan stating how they will tailor their

"Educational Triage" and the Texas Accountability System

instruction to these objectives for the following 9 weeks. At BES, this component of the planning process remains ceremonial. Teachers calculate the numbers for each objective and formulate plans but do not rely on them in planning their lessons. This information takes a backseat to aggregate pass rates.

¹⁵This teacher referred to these students as the "pink ones" because teachers must color-code their students' scores on test score summary sheets. If a student scores above 70%, she or he is colored blue. Scores between 60% and 69% are colored green, and those below 60% are colored pink.

¹⁶Third-grade students in the 2002–2003 school year were the first cohort required to pass the new state reading test, the TAKS, to be promoted to the fourth grade. The state offers third-grade students three opportunities to pass the reading test. In the case of any students who fail the first test (administered at the beginning of March), the school must place them in classes with reduced student-teacher ratios (10:1 as opposed to 22:1) throughout the duration of their literacy instruction each day (3 hours per day in the district I studied). If a student fails the second test at the end of April, the school must form a "grade placement committee" (GPC) composed of the teacher, principal, and parent to determine whether the student should take the final test in July or be retained. If the committee opts for the student to take the exam, the student attends summer school (20 days in the district I studied) and receives reading instruction for 6 hours each day. In the event that the student fails the final test, the GPC reconvenes. If all members of the GPC vote to promote the student, the student may be promoted. Otherwise, the student must repeat the third grade (TEA, 2003b).

¹⁷To allow for comparison across the year, I used the metric established by the district in constructing this graph: (a) mastery, 70% or above; (b) bubble, 60%–69%; and (c) remedial, below 60%. Accordingly, students represented in the "bubble" category for the March test actually passed the state test, as did a small percentage of those represented as remedial.

¹⁸In the 2002–2003 school year, Texas tests shifted from the older TAAS to the newer TAKS, which reflected new state standards. Brickland had been using 70% as the cut score, as the percentage of questions a student needed to answer correctly to pass the TAAS was approximately 70%. When the tests changed to reflect more difficult content, the cut score was shifted downward. The pass rate was set at two standard errors of measurement below the recommendation of the state board of education in the first year of implementation of the new tests. For example, in the 2003–2004 school year students were required to answer 61.1% of questions correctly to pass the reading test, and in 2004–2005 they were required to correctly answer 66.7% of questions to pass (TEA, 2003d).

¹⁹Gillborn and Youdell (2000) also made this argument about the systems of prediction employed by the schools they studied.

²⁰One reviewer suggested that this characterization of the "invisibility" of students overstated teachers' stances toward special education students. Consequently, in the second analysis of the data, I specifically sought disconfirming evidence that highlighted the nuanced nature of teachers' explanations and actions. I did not uncover such evidence. It is my opinion that these students are deemphasized in their classrooms and in the school in the following ways: (a) They do not participate in the test preparation activities that dominate much of class time, (b) they are not targeted for additional tutoring after school or on Saturdays, and (c) they are not given benchmark tests to gauge their progress, and, as a result, their academic needs are not taken into account in planning classroom activities.

²¹I am discussing the most prominent type of classification for special education in this district. There are other designations, such as "emotionally disturbed" and "behaviorally disturbed," that involve a different battery of tests.

²²This criterion for special education classification is not a district policy; rather, it is derived from federal law as outlined in the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act, which was most recently amended in 1997.

²³It is important to note, however, that the analysis described in this section should not be understood as making a direct causal argument between the Brickland district's response to the accountability system and the acrimonious nature of teacher relationships reported here. Surely, it is possible that the causal arrow points in the other direction; widespread distrust could have existed at BES before the inception of the accountability

system and the district's adoption of data-driven decision making in response. Thus, lacking data collected before the inception of the accountability system in 1993, I cannot make definitive claims about increases or declines in relational trust. Despite these limitations, Brickland's response to the accountability system, at the very least, exacerbated existing tensions between teachers and is therefore an object worthy of attention.

²⁴As a clarification, "placing" a student means recommending summer school with the promotion decision to be made at the end of the summer. The Brickland district, until the state's institution of the third-grade policy, would allow a student to be retained only once between kindergarten and third grade.

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"Educational Triage" and the Texas Accountability System

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"Educational Triage" and the Texas Accountability System

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